

PETER

I'm talking about up here.

(Peter taps his helmet.)

PETER (CONT'D)

That's your first kill, right?
Right Em? Come back to me. That's
your first kill?

EMILIAN

I'm fine!

PETER

I didn't say anything was wrong Em,
you gotta snap back though. There
might be more coming.

EMILIAN

Shut the fuck up Pete.

(Peter startles at the vulgarity. He pauses to gather his thoughts, lost in a memory he obviously doesn't like to revisit. He peeks over the foxhole carefully. The night is quiet once more. The terror has passed, for now.)

PETER

The first kill I saw in person was
in Iraq-

EMILIAN

I don't want to hear about it.

(They both huddle down behind the sandbags)

PETER

I'm trailing a unit sweeping a
neighborhood and this guy comes
bursting out of a door. He's got
something in his hands and the look
on his face tells me it's not a
bouquet of flowers. The marine next
to me put him down in one shot.

EMILIAN

He did what he had to right?
Right!? Just like I did. We're the
good guys, they're the bad guys.
End of story.

PETER

They rolled the guy over and he's
got a rock in his hand.

EMILIAN

It's still a weapon.

PETER

If I had to live it again, I'd want that marine to waste him every single time.

EMILIAN

Then why are you talking about it?

PETER

The guy was this pudgy dad. Who knows what he'd been dealing with. The fact he grabbed a rock and charged tells me he wasn't the fucking one of Taliban. He was just a guy. He had kids, he had dreams other than war-

EMILIAN

Yeah, he dreamed of killing you. He's an animal and the world is better off without him.

(Emilian checks the horizon with binoculars)

PETER

You say he dreamed of killing me, right? What drew me to cover warzones was that I almost enlisted. No joke. I wanted to chase that adventure. I even dreamed about that specific moment. As a reporter, I soaked up stories from soldiers the whole time picturing some sort of glorious justified killing. If dreaming about killing someone makes you a monster worth killing then I was just as guilty. I was just luckier that day. All the time and family it took to bring the two of us together in one moment and, poof, he's gone in a cloud of blood.

(Emilian stares intently, anger building in his already tense body.)

EMILIAN

No. There's right and there's wrong; good and evil.

PETER
Who defines what's good?

EMILIAN
Fuck off Pete. Not now.

PETER
Thou shalt not kill?

EMILIAN
That's for murder. What I just did
was part of war. It's different.

PETER
Always an "It's not like that", eh?

EMILIAN
It's not an out clause, it's the
original Hebrew text. You shall not
murder is-

PETER
Ah, right, God so divinely inspired
the writing of his rules that they
can be easily confused with human
language differences.

EMILIAN
At least I have a moral code. Where
do you draw yours from? Or do you
just steal what you can from your
dad and live on the scraps from
people like me?

(The words sting Peter, but he presses on.)

PETER
This atheist guy I knew told me
about a philosopher. Rolls or
something. He was gonna be a
priest.

EMILIAN
Your friend?

PETER
No. Rolls or whatever. Anyway, he
was a soldier in World War Two.
He's all in on the God shit when he
sees the carnage after the bomb in
Hiroshima. He can't square it.

(Emilian shrugs and simmers.)